

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Hairdressing and Barbering English



Conversation lab

8 complete workplace dialogues, followed by eight additional role-play cases. Study the exchanges, then make the conversation your own.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For Hairstylists, barbers, salon assistants, and salon reception staff.

All clients, prices, timings, products, and incidents are fictional English practice. This course is not training in cutting, shaving, chemical services, infection control, or diagnosis. Technical suitability and any health concern require the appropriately qualified professional and applicable local procedures. Sample salon policies are not universal rules.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Inside this conversation lab

Original fictional training conversations in professional English. These are realistic scripts, not transcripts of actual people. The professional roles are the speaker labels; all figures, incidents, and organizations are invented.

01 The parent and the wearer want different lengths

02 A wedding look and the Monday morning routine

03 The same photograph looks different on two screens

04 The reminder shows the wrong visit

05 A client changes their mind about the wash

06 An old voucher and a current service menu

07 A complaint belongs to the person wearing the haircut

08 A visiting stylist needs the current preference

Then try eight independent role-play cases, followed by feedback criteria and references.

Read it. Hear it. Make it yours.

1. Read the setting. Identify the roles, the immediate problem, and what each speaker needs.
2. Read the whole conversation aloud with a partner. In a group, give a third person the observer role. For three-speaker scripts, assign each professional a separate voice.
3. Notice how the speakers ask a specific question, qualify a claim, disagree, explain a technical point, or agree on a next step. Underline language you would actually use.
4. Cover the script. Recreate the exchange using the situation and professional roles. Keep the meaning, but change the wording.
5. Switch roles and introduce a complication: a missing record, a different priority, an unavailable colleague, or a changed assumption. End with a clear outcome or unresolved question.

Register and terminology

These colleagues use concise professional language. In an internal technical meeting, familiar abbreviations can be natural. With a new colleague or a client, expand unfamiliar terms and check understanding. Keep disagreement directed at the evidence or proposal, and match the degree of certainty to what is known.

Independent study

Speak each role aloud. Pause before the reply and supply your own response before revealing the next line. Record a second version using invented details, then compare its clarity and tone with the script.

Professional context

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FULL DIALOGUE 01 / 12 SPEAKING TURNS

The parent and the wearer want different lengths

A stylist checks a teenage client's preferences; booking permission is already settled.

Roles: Stylist / Client

Stylist: Your parent showed me a short photograph. Which parts of it appeal to you personally?

Client: I want neater hair, but I don't want my ears completely exposed like that.

Stylist: Which areas bother you now, and which lengths would you prefer to keep today?

Client: The front falls into my eyes. I like tucking the sides behind my ears.

Stylist: Then let's discuss the front separately. We don't have to copy the whole photograph.

Client: Can we explain that? My parent thinks booking a haircut means agreeing to their photograph.

Stylist: We'll summarize your preference together. First, do you want any change at the back?

Client: Only a neater outline. I don't want the much shorter back shown in the picture.

Stylist: So, a clearer front, retained side length, and a discussion of the back before cutting.

Client: Yes. Please show me the proposed front length because short means different things to us.

Stylist: I'll indicate the point in the mirror. Nothing in this photograph overrides what we've agreed.

Client: That gives me something specific to explain. We're changing the front, not copying everything.

Notice the professional language

'Discuss the front separately' limits a preference to one area.

'What we've agreed' distinguishes the client's decision from a suggested photograph.

Rehearse this dialogue with an AI partner

FULL DIALOGUE 02 / 12 SPEAKING TURNS

A wedding look and the Monday morning routine

A stylist separates an event finish from an everyday haircut.

Roles: Stylist / Client

Stylist: You've shown me two different photographs. Which one represents the haircut you want every day?

Client: The wavy one. I only want the smooth, fuller finish for Saturday's wedding ceremony.

Stylist: Then let's separate the underlying shape from the styling for that occasion. What matters on Monday?

Client: I need to wear my natural waves and leave quickly, without arranging the front carefully.

Stylist: The event picture has more front volume, whereas your everyday reference has a softer outline.

Client: I like that extra volume for Saturday. Does it require a completely different haircut today?

Stylist: The picture alone doesn't establish that. We'll discuss possible finishes after agreeing on the shape.

Client: Please don't shorten the front because it looks shorter when swept back in that photograph.

Stylist: Understood. We'll assess actual length separately from how it's arranged. The retained front length matters.

Client: Could the event request have its own booking note, so another stylist doesn't misunderstand it?

Stylist: Yes: everyday waves for the cut; a separate event consultation, with Saturday's availability still unconfirmed.

Client: That's accurate. I'll choose today's cut around my routine and wait before arranging Saturday's transport.

Notice the professional language

'Underlying shape' distinguishes a haircut from a temporary finish.

'Whereas' makes a direct contrast between two reference images.

Rehearse this dialogue with an AI partner

FULL DIALOGUE 03 / 12 SPEAKING TURNS

The same photograph looks different on two screens

A stylist and client compare a phone photograph with the salon's printed reference.

Roles: Stylist / Client

Stylist: Your phone image looks cooler than this print. Which appearance did you want to discuss?

Client: The phone version. I increased its brightness, but didn't consider how that might affect our consultation.

Stylist: That may change how the image appears. We can use physical samples to clarify the tone you prefer.

Client: I prefer this sample. Does choosing it confirm the final result, or is more discussion needed?

Stylist: It identifies a target, not a guarantee. Your starting color and previous services still require a professional assessment.

Client: I used a home color but can't recall which. Last time, brighter was mistaken for much lighter.

Stylist: Then let's avoid that broad word. Does less golden describe your preference more accurately than much lighter?

Client: Yes, less golden is exactly what I mean. I don't want the photograph's apparent lightness copied automatically.

Stylist: I'll note cooler tone requested, lightness retained, and the home product still unidentified.

Client: Can we compare the samples again when I bring that product information, rather than choose the service now?

Stylist: Yes. We'll revisit the consultation with the additional history before discussing suitability, a service estimate, or an appointment.

Client: I'll bring the details Thursday. That's another discussion, not treatment; the sample records my preference.

Notice the professional language

'Identifies a target, not a guarantee' limits what a sample establishes.

Replacing 'brighter' with 'less golden' repairs an ambiguous color description.

Rehearse this dialogue with an AI partner

FULL DIALOGUE 04 / 12 SPEAKING TURNS

The reminder shows the wrong visit

A client calls after receiving reminders for two salon appointments.

Roles: Receptionist / Client

Receptionist: Please read both reminders' dates and services so we can check each booking.

Client: Tuesday says consultation at ten, and Thursday says haircut at two. I thought Thursday replaced Tuesday completely.

Receptionist: I see the haircut was moved, but the consultation entry remained. Did you still want that separate discussion?

Client: No. Tuesday was for a possible color change, and I've decided not to pursue color at the moment.

Receptionist: Then you're asking to cancel the consultation only, while keeping Thursday's haircut at two. Have I understood correctly?

Client: Exactly. Please don't remove both because the messages use the same general heading.

Receptionist: I've removed Tuesday's consultation and kept Thursday's haircut. The updated schedule now shows only that appointment for you.

Client: Will the earlier Tuesday reminder still appear on my phone? I don't want to mistake it for a new booking.

Receptionist: The old message may remain on your phone; it doesn't override today's confirmed cancellation.

Client: Please send Thursday's date, time, and service so I can check my calendar.

Receptionist: Yes, I'll send the haircut confirmation now. The appointment list here shows Thursday at two, without Tuesday's consultation.

Client: I've received it. That matches my calendar, and I understand that the earlier reminder is no longer current.

Notice the professional language

'Cancel ... only, while keeping ...' protects the appointment that should remain.

'Message history' distinguishes an old notification from a current booking record.

Rehearse this dialogue with an AI partner

FULL DIALOGUE 05 / 12 SPEAKING TURNS

A client changes their mind about the wash

A client decides against a wash before the service begins.

Roles: Stylist / Client

Stylist: You seem hesitant about the basin. Your booking includes a wash; what would you prefer?

Client: I'd rather not have the wash today. I felt uncomfortable there previously and don't want another attempt.

Stylist: Thank you for telling me before we start. Are you asking to remove the wash from today's request?

Client: Yes, but would changing that cancel the whole visit?

Stylist: Let's clarify the remaining service with reception. Changing the request doesn't automatically settle timing or price.

Client: I understand. I still want to discuss the haircut, but I don't want pressure to use the basin.

Stylist: We'll keep that preference explicit while the stylist assesses the revised request.

Client: Could you tell reception that I declined the wash, rather than saying I refused the whole appointment?

Stylist: Yes. Your haircut consultation remains open, and the wash is no longer requested. We haven't started either service.

Client: That accurately describes my choice. Please let me hear the revised estimate before I decide about continuing today.

Stylist: Reception has confirmed a consultation now, with the revised service estimate to follow after the stylist's assessment.

Client: I'll stay for that discussion. I haven't agreed to the revised service yet, but I'm comfortable discussing it.

Notice the professional language

'No longer requested' states a changed preference without assigning blame.

'Doesn't automatically settle' separates a changed request from its scheduling and price consequences.

Rehearse this dialogue with an AI partner

FULL DIALOGUE 06 / 12 SPEAKING TURNS

An old voucher and a current service menu

A receptionist checks a salon voucher with its owner.

Roles: Receptionist / Client

Receptionist: Your voucher states a fifty-dollar value. Which service were you expecting it to cover at today's appointment?

Client: I thought it covered any haircut and finish because the gift envelope has a photograph of both.

Receptionist: The voucher itself specifies an amount, not a named package. Today's combined service price is sixty dollars.

Client: So there would be ten dollars remaining to pay if I choose both services at that price?

Receptionist: Yes, under this voucher's stated terms. You could instead choose the forty-five-dollar haircut and retain five dollars.

Client: I don't want a finish today. Would using less than the full value cancel the remaining balance?

Receptionist: Not here. Its terms preserve unused balances; I'll show you the relevant line.

Client: Please do. I'd rather check the actual wording than assume the gift envelope describes all the conditions.

Receptionist: Here it is: unused value remains available. The receipt will show forty-five used and five remaining.

Client: That answers my question. I'll choose the haircut and keep the balance for another visit to this salon.

Receptionist: I've noted that choice. The voucher doesn't add a finishing service, and there is no extra payment today.

Client: Good. Please give me the balance receipt so I can keep it with the voucher afterward.

Notice the professional language

'An amount, not a named package' explains what the voucher actually promises.

'Under this voucher's stated terms' keeps the explanation specific to the fictional offer.

Rehearse this dialogue with an AI partner

FULL DIALOGUE 07 / 12 SPEAKING TURNS

A complaint belongs to the person wearing the haircut

A receptionist speaks with the client after a friend posts a critical salon comment.

Roles: Receptionist / Client

Receptionist: Your friend called about yesterday's appointment. I'd like to hear your own concern before arranging a review.

Client: My friend dislikes the short sides, but I chose them. I'm concerned only about the front length.

Receptionist: Thank you for separating those points. Which detail at the front differs from what you requested yesterday?

Client: I wanted it clear of my eyes. It still falls forward when I wear it normally.

Receptionist: So your request concerns the front, not changing the sides back to the friend's preferred appearance?

Client: Exactly. Please don't book an adjustment based on the comment they posted without asking me first.

Receptionist: I won't treat that comment as your instruction. We can arrange a discussion with your stylist.

Client: Can I have that discussion before deciding whether any further cutting is appropriate for the front?

Receptionist: Yes. A review is available tomorrow at eleven, with no adjustment agreed in advance of it.

Client: That suits me. I want the stylist to see how the front falls before suggesting anything.

Receptionist: I'll note your specific concern and confirm the review time. Your friend's preference won't replace yours.

Client: Thank you. That's a fair description, and I can explain the front issue myself tomorrow.

Notice the professional language

'Your own concern' separates the client's request from a third party's opinion.

'No adjustment agreed in advance' preserves the purpose of a review appointment.

Rehearse this dialogue with an AI partner

FULL DIALOGUE 08 / 12 SPEAKING TURNS

A visiting stylist needs the current preference

A receptionist gives a visiting stylist a handover before a returning client's consultation.

Roles: Receptionist / Stylist

Receptionist: The client's old record shows a fringe, but today's request says keep the front long.

Stylist: Thanks. Was that current request confirmed with the client, or copied from the previous stylist's own suggestion?

Receptionist: The client stated it on the phone this morning. They want to tuck the front behind their ears.

Stylist: Then I'll use the old photograph as background only, not as permission to recreate the shorter fringe.

Receptionist: They also asked whether a longer consultation is possible because they're considering a different outline for work.

Stylist: Does the appointment include more time, or is that request still awaiting an answer?

Receptionist: I added fifteen minutes with the client's agreement, so today's slot includes that additional discussion time.

Stylist: Good. What remains open is the shape decision, not the amount of consultation time we've reserved today.

Receptionist: Exactly. Please ask the client to confirm the proposed outline in the mirror before treating it as agreed.

Stylist: I will. Are there any other preferences from this morning that I should hear before the client arrives?

Receptionist: They requested no promotional photographs, separately from the older reference image in their record.

Stylist: Understood: longer front requested, extra discussion time confirmed, final outline undecided, and no promotional photograph requested today.

Notice the professional language

'Background only' prevents an old record from overriding a current request.

'What remains open is ...' identifies the actual undecided part of a handover.

Rehearse this dialogue with an AI partner

Eight more situations to make your own

The following cases are open role plays. They give you facts, contrasting roles, useful expressions, and a short model response. Use what you learned from the complete dialogues to create a longer exchange.

Preparation: two minutes. Conversation: three to five minutes. Feedback: one minute. Switch roles and repeat with the second-round challenge.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 01

Turning a reference photo into a clear request

SHARED CASE

A client shows a chin-length bob but wants to keep enough length for a low ponytail. No cut has started. The photo has a straight fringe; the client has not requested one. Clarify which features matter and confirm a collarbone-length outline.

Role A | Responding professional

Resolve conflicting length preferences before a haircut. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

Client: you like the photo's neat outline, not its short length or fringe; you need a low ponytail.

Useful expressions

Which part of the photo would you like to keep?

When you say short, do you mean ___?

Could you confirm whether you want ___?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Your photo has a shorter outline and a straight fringe, but keeping a low ponytail matters to you. Which feature of the photo do you want to keep? We can discuss a collarbone-length outline instead. Before we start, please confirm whether you want any change around your forehead.

Second round

The client points to the fringe while saying 'this shape.' Ask whether the gesture changes the earlier preference.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 02

Describing shape, texture, and everyday styling

SHARED CASE

A client wants less fullness at the neckline but does not want exposed skin at the sides. Photo A, labelled 'low taper,' shows visible hair covering the sides. Photo B, labelled 'skin fade,' shows exposed skin at the shortest area of the sides. The client spends five minutes styling each morning. Compare these supplied appearances, not cutting methods or guaranteed upkeep.

Role A | Responding professional

Use the same appearance and routine criteria for two styles. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

Client: prefer covered sides and less fullness at the neckline; you style for five minutes in the morning.

Useful expressions

In this photo, ___, whereas in that one, ___.

Both give ___, but only this image shows ___.

How much time do you normally spend on ___?

Cover this until after your first attempt

In these photos, the low taper keeps more visible hair at the sides, whereas the skin fade exposes skin at the shortest area. You said you want less fullness at the neckline without that exposed look. Let's discuss the taper image as a reference and check how it fits your usual five-minute routine.

Second round

The client assumes 'low' means the same length in both photos. Clarify the actual area being compared.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 03

Discussing color without promising a photograph

SHARED CASE

A client wants the cool tone in a photograph before Friday. Their previous home color product is unknown. Today's booking is a consultation only; suitability, service time, and cost have not been assessed.

Role A | Responding professional

Describe a color preference while preserving genuine uncertainty. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

Client: want a cooler appearance before Friday; you remember home coloring but not the product.

Useful expressions

The photo shows ____; it doesn't establish ____.

We still need to know ____.

Today's booking covers ____, not ____.

Cover this until after your first attempt

The photograph helps us discuss the cool tone you prefer, but it doesn't establish what we can achieve by Friday. Your previous color product is still unknown. Today is a consultation; we need to review your color history before confirming a service, timing, or price.

Second round

The client says the photograph proves it is possible in one visit. Explain the limit of that evidence.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 04

Booking time and handling appointment changes

SHARED CASE

A haircut appointment at 2:00 is running twenty minutes late. The usual service duration is forty minutes. The client must leave by 2:45. A 10:00 appointment tomorrow is available; the stylist cannot promise a shortened service today. This salon waives the change fee when its delay causes this rescheduling.

Role A | Responding professional

Negotiate appointments without disguising a timing conflict. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

Client: must leave by 2:45 today; tomorrow at ten is possible if today's complete service will not fit.

Useful expressions

We are running ___ behind.

That would take us past ___.

Would tomorrow at ___ work instead?

Cover this until after your first attempt

We're twenty minutes behind, and the usual forty-minute service would take us past your 2:45 departure. I can't promise to compress it into that time. Tomorrow at ten is available. Would you prefer that appointment, or to discuss another time that gives you the full slot?

Second round

The client offers to skip the consultation. Keep the complete appointment's timing and assessment needs clear.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 05

Checking comfort and pausing clearly

SHARED CASE

Before a wash, a client says the neck support feels uncomfortable. Water has not started. Ask the client to describe the pressure, pause preparation, and arrange a comfort check. Do not diagnose the discomfort or prescribe a position.

Role A | Responding professional

Ask a specific comfort question and acknowledge the answer. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

Client: feel pressure at the back of the neck before washing; want to sit up and discuss comfort.

Useful expressions

Where does ___ feel uncomfortable?

I'll pause while we check ___.

Would you prefer to stop ___?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Please tell me where the support feels uncomfortable before we begin. We haven't started the water, and I'll pause here while we check the arrangement with you. You don't need to put up with discomfort to keep the appointment moving. Let me know whether you want to leave the basin.

Second round

The client apologizes for slowing the appointment. Acknowledge the concern without minimizing the discomfort.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 06

Explaining services, prices, and product choices

SHARED CASE

The fictional menu lists a haircut at \$45 and an optional finish at \$15, with no other charges in this exercise. A client thinks \$45 includes the finish. Neither service has begun. Explain the \$60 combined total and the \$45 haircut-only choice.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate included services from optional additions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

Client: assumed the finish was included; can spend sixty but want a genuine choice.

Useful expressions

The price includes ___, but not ___.

Together, the total would be ___.

Would you like ___ alone or ___ as well?

Cover this until after your first attempt

The forty-five-dollar price covers the haircut; the finish is an optional fifteen-dollar addition. Together they would be sixty dollars, with no other charges. You can choose the haircut alone for forty-five. Which option would you like me to confirm before we begin?

Second round

The client asks whether buying a product makes the finish free. No such offer exists in the supplied menu.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 07

Responding to a concern about the result

SHARED CASE

A client says the left side looks longer. The earlier explanation promised an even outline, but the current appearance has not been reviewed together. Pause checkout, acknowledge the concern, and offer mirror review with the stylist. No correction or refund has been approved.

Role A | Responding professional

Repair an expectation mismatch without arguing or inventing a solution. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

Client: the left appears longer; want to show the difference without being dismissed.

Useful expressions

You're noticing ___ on ___.

Let's look at that area together.

We haven't yet agreed on ___.

Cover this until after your first attempt

You were expecting an even outline, and you're noticing a longer-looking section on the left. I'm sorry this hasn't been addressed before checkout. Let's look at the area together with the stylist. We haven't agreed on an adjustment or refund yet; first we need to understand the specific concern.

Second round

The client asks whether acknowledging the concern means the salon has approved a free adjustment.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 08

Passing preferences to the next appointment

SHARED CASE

A client requests a future color consultation but has not booked it. Reception is taking over. Today's confirmed preferences are retained front length and no finishing spray. The client has not agreed to promotional photographs. Handover the preferences and unbooked request accurately.

Role A | Responding professional

Give a concise handover with an identifiable next task. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

Receptionist: need to offer consultation dates and keep today's preferences separate from a future service.

Useful expressions

Today the client chose ____.

They asked about ____; nothing is booked yet.

Please confirm ____ directly with the client.

Cover this until after your first attempt

Today's preferences were to retain the front length and leave out finishing spray. The client asked about a future color consultation, but no date is booked. Please offer available consultation times and confirm the choice directly. There is no agreement to promotional photography, so the visit note should not imply permission.

Second round

The client consents to an internal reference photo but not publication. Repeat the limited permission.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

Lesson conversations and speaking practice

The following sections match 05 and 06 on the industry webpage and in the learner workbook. Each lesson has three ten-turn conversations and two bounded speaking scenarios. These are original fictional teaching scripts, not transcripts of real people.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

A bob photograph with a ponytail requirement

A first consultation before any cutting.

01 • Stylist: What appeals to you about this reference photo: the length, the fringe, or the outline?

02 • Client: Mostly the neat outline. I still need to tie my hair back at work.

03 • Stylist: The pictured length ends at the chin. That conflicts with your low ponytail requirement.

04 • Client: I hadn't noticed how short it was. Could we keep it near my collarbone?

05 • Stylist: Let's discuss that longer perimeter. Are you also asking for hair across your forehead?

06 • Client: No fringe, please. I wear glasses, and I like keeping the front tucked away.

07 • Stylist: So the photograph guides the outline, not the length or the front section.

08 • Client: Exactly. Could you show me the proposed length in the mirror before starting?

09 • Stylist: Yes, here is the point we discussed. Does this match what you meant?

10 • Client: It does. Keep that length, and leave the front long enough to tuck.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

What does a tidy-up include?

A barber clarifies a returning client's brief request.

01 • Barber: When you say a tidy-up today, which parts feel too long or untidy?

02 • Client: Around my ears, mainly. I'm growing the top out for a different style.

03 • Barber: Then shortening the top isn't part of your request. What about the neckline?

04 • Client: That needs attention too, but I don't want the whole cut much shorter.

05 • Barber: Understood. Your last appointment note says a short all-over cut; today's preference differs.

06 • Client: Yes, please don't use that old description. I've been growing it for weeks.

07 • Barber: I'll record that you're keeping the top and changing the outline around the ears.

08 • Client: Could you also check the back with me? I can't describe it very well.

09 • Barber: Certainly. We'll use the hand mirror to agree on the outline together first.

10 • Client: That helps. The top stays long, and we agree on the edges before starting.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Bangs and fringe mean the same area

A visitor uses a different regional word at the salon.

01 • Stylist: You mentioned bangs on the phone. Our booking note uses fringe; that's the same area.

02 • Client: Good, because I wondered whether I'd booked a completely different kind of haircut.

03 • Stylist: No, the words vary. What length do you have in mind across your forehead?

04 • Client: I want it below my eyebrows, not as short as the display photograph.

05 • Stylist: Thank you. Would you like the center and the sides discussed separately today?

06 • Client: Yes. I like longer pieces at the sides, but I don't know their name.

07 • Stylist: You don't need the technical name. Point to the areas you want to retain.

08 • Client: These pieces here. I usually tuck them behind my ears when I'm working.

09 • Stylist: I see. We'll keep those longer and confirm the center length in the mirror.

10 • Client: That's the distinction I was trying to explain. Please keep those side pieces.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Turning a reference photo into a clear request

A client shows a chin-length bob but wants to keep enough length for a low ponytail. No cut has started. The photo has a straight fringe; the client has not requested one. Clarify which features matter and confirm a collarbone-length outline.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Client: you like the photo's neat outline, not its short length or fringe; you need a low ponytail.

Second round: The client points to the fringe while saying 'this shape.' Ask whether the gesture changes the earlier preference.

Scenario 2 | Two photographs, one preferred feature

A client brings one photo for the back outline and another for the long front. Both show shorter overall hair than the client wants. The client needs shoulder length.

Role A: Stylist: identify one feature from each photo and confirm the retained length.

Role B: Client: choose the rounded back from photo A and long front from photo B; reject their overall length.

Possible opening: Can I combine the back from this picture with the front from that one?

Success checks

- Identify the chosen feature in each photo.
- Confirm shoulder length independently of the photographs.
- Restate the combined request aloud before proceeding.

Add a complication: The client calls both pictures 'the shorter one.' Ask them to point to A or B.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Covered sides or a skin-level finish?

A barber compares two reference images with a client.

01 • Barber: These photographs show different side lengths. Which feature matters more to you today?

02 • Client: I want the neckline less bulky, but I don't want skin showing at the sides.

03 • Barber: In this taper photograph, the sides keep more coverage than in the skin fade.

04 • Client: Then the taper picture sounds closer. Does its name tell you exactly what I want?

05 • Barber: Not completely. We still need to agree on the visible length and overall shape.

06 • Client: I also have only five minutes in the morning, so elaborate styling won't suit me.

07 • Barber: How do you normally wear the top: brushed back, to the side, or natural?

08 • Client: Usually to the side with very little product. I want to keep doing that.

09 • Barber: We'll use the covered sides as our reference and discuss the top around that routine.

10 • Client: Yes, that comparison helps more than just choosing a haircut name from the menu.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Layers without losing the outer length

A salon consultation separates internal shape from the outside outline.

01 • Stylist: You asked about layers but also said the overall length must stay the same.

02 • Client: Right. I thought layers always meant making the whole haircut much shorter than it is.

03 • Stylist: Layers concern different lengths within the shape; the outside outline is a separate choice.

04 • Client: Can I have more movement without making it shorter overall?

05 • Stylist: Yes. Which reference image shows the kind of movement you're describing around the front?

06 • Client: This one does, though I don't like the very short pieces near the face.

07 • Stylist: That's important. We can discuss the longer sections without copying those shorter front pieces.

08 • Client: Please show me which parts you mean. I'm better with pictures than technical descriptions.

09 • Stylist: Here and here. Does that match your request to keep the outer length visible?

10 • Client: Yes, keep the overall length. Show me where the shorter layers would be.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

The finish should reflect the usual curls

A client asks about a style photographed on straightened hair.

01 • Stylist: The reference photograph shows a smooth finish. Do you usually wear your hair straight?

02 • Client: No, I wear my natural curls almost every day and rarely spend time straightening them.

03 • Stylist: Then we should discuss how you want the shape to look with your usual texture.

04 • Client: I like the photograph's outline, but I wasn't asking for that exact straight finish.

05 • Stylist: Thank you for clarifying. Would seeing a curly reference help us discuss the same outline?

06 • Client: Yes, particularly at the sides. That's where I want the shape to feel less wide.

07 • Stylist: This second picture may be a better discussion point, although your result won't be identical.

08 • Client: I understand. I want a clear idea, not a promise that my curls will match.

09 • Stylist: Tell me what you like in this one, and we'll agree on those features.

10 • Client: The softer sides and retained top length are the features I'd like to discuss.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Describing shape, texture, and everyday styling

A client wants less fullness at the neckline but does not want exposed skin at the sides. Photo A, labelled 'low taper,' shows visible hair covering the sides. Photo B, labelled 'skin fade,' shows exposed skin at the shortest area of the sides. The client spends five minutes styling each morning. Compare these supplied appearances, not cutting methods or guaranteed upkeep.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Client: prefer covered sides and less fullness at the neckline; you style for five minutes in the morning.

Second round: The client assumes 'low' means the same length in both photos. Clarify the actual area being compared.

Scenario 2 | A beard photograph with an unfamiliar label

A client requests a 'fade' after seeing a beard photograph. They mean a softer transition at the sideburns, not a shorter beard overall. The client likes the current chin length.

Role A: Barber: distinguish sideburn appearance from overall beard length.

Role B: Client: protect the chin length and point to the transition in the photograph.

Possible opening: When I say fade, I mean this part near my ears.

Success checks

- Identify the actual area in the photo.
- Keep overall beard length separate from the transition.
- Confirm appearance preferences without explaining tool techniques.

Add a complication: The client asks whether the service name alone guarantees the pictured result.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

A Friday target is not a confirmed result

A client attends a color consultation.

01 • Stylist: Your photo shows a cool tone. Is that what you want, rather than extra lightness?

02 • Client: Yes, especially before Friday. Can I book exactly that result for the party?

03 • Stylist: First we need your color history. Do you know which home product you used?

04 • Client: I remember the box being red, but I don't remember the product name.

05 • Stylist: That leaves an important detail unknown. The photo can't confirm what is suitable here.

06 • Client: I thought today's consultation included the color service. Was that my mistake when booking?

07 • Stylist: The booking is for discussion only. We haven't assessed the service time or cost.

08 • Client: I'll look for the packaging when I get home. Can we still discuss the target?

09 • Stylist: Certainly. We can identify your preferred tone without promising a particular result by Friday.

10 • Client: Then let's do that. I won't treat this consultation as a confirmed color appointment.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Warmth is not the same as darkness

A client compares two salon shade samples.

01 • Stylist: You called both samples dark, but pointed to the golden one as your concern.

02 • Client: I struggle to describe it. The other sample looks calmer, even at similar depth.

03 • Stylist: Are you referring to the warm golden tone rather than how light it is?

04 • Client: Yes, that's closer. I don't necessarily want my hair made lighter this time.

05 • Stylist: Then we can discuss a less warm target without assuming a change in lightness.

06 • Client: Would calling it ash guarantee the exact shade on this sample ring for me?

07 • Stylist: No. The sample helps identify a preference; your own result needs an individual assessment.

08 • Client: That makes sense. Could you keep these two ideas separate in the consultation note?

09 • Stylist: Yes: less warmth requested, with no automatic request for lighter hair or new highlights.

10 • Client: That's the wording I needed. It avoids making the change sound larger than intended.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Remembering the missing appointment history

A stylist asks a returning client about an incomplete record.

01 • Stylist: Our note lists your last color visit. Is today's request about regrowth or the colored lengths?

02 • Client: The regrowth near my roots. I also used temporary color at home before my holiday.

03 • Stylist: Please include it in your history without guessing how it affects today's options.

04 • Client: I don't know the name, but my sister ordered it and may have the receipt.

05 • Stylist: That could help identify it. Shall we leave that part marked as unknown for now?

06 • Client: Yes. Please don't record that I haven't used anything just because I can't remember.

07 • Stylist: I'll state that a home product was used and its name remains unconfirmed.

08 • Client: Could we discuss haircut options today while the color question is still open?

09 • Stylist: We can discuss them separately. That doesn't decide whether a color service is suitable.

10 • Client: Good. I'll ask for the receipt, and today's conversation won't erase that missing detail.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Discussing color without promising a photograph

A client wants the cool tone in a photograph before Friday. Their previous home color product is unknown. Today's booking is a consultation only; suitability, service time, and cost have not been assessed.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Client: want a cooler appearance before Friday; you remember home coloring but not the product.

Second round: The client says the photograph proves it is possible in one visit. Explain the limit of that evidence.

Scenario 2 | A highlight request becomes an all-over question

A client booked a consultation about a few lighter sections but now wants the whole head to match a pale photograph. No service has been booked.

Role A: Stylist: distinguish selected highlights from the new overall request.

Role B: Client: want the pale appearance but cannot provide previous product details.

Possible opening: Does asking for highlights mean the whole head will look like this?

Success checks

- Separate highlighted sections from the all-over request.
- Identify the missing history.
- Keep service price and consultation price distinct.

Add a complication: The client assumes the consultation price is the price of either service.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

The departure time cannot move

Reception discusses the delayed 2:00 haircut.

01 • Receptionist: I'm sorry, we're running twenty minutes behind your two o'clock appointment this afternoon.

02 • Client: I need to leave by quarter to three. Is the full haircut still possible?

03 • Receptionist: The usual forty-minute service from 2:20 would finish around three, beyond your departure.

04 • Client: Could the stylist just work faster? I already arranged transport for today.

05 • Receptionist: I can't promise a compressed service. There is a full slot tomorrow at ten.

06 • Client: Tomorrow is possible, but would changing it count as my cancelling at short notice?

07 • Receptionist: This change is due to our delay; I can move it without a change fee.

08 • Client: Then please move it. I don't want to feel rushed through the consultation.

09 • Receptionist: You're booked tomorrow at ten for the full slot, and today's appointment is replaced.

10 • Client: Thanks for stating the timing clearly. I'll rearrange my ride for the new appointment.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A walk-in between booked clients

A barber explains current availability to a visitor.

01 • Barber: Are you looking for a haircut today, or checking our next available booking first?

02 • Client: I was hoping to walk in. I can see an empty chair by the window.

03 • Barber: That chair has a booking starting shortly; an empty chair doesn't always mean available time.

04 • Client: I only need a small change. Could I take part of that appointment slot?

05 • Barber: We need enough time for the complete visit. The next open haircut slot is four.

06 • Client: I could return at four. Would I still have to join the walk-in queue then?

07 • Barber: If we book that slot now, you'll have an appointment rather than a queue place.

08 • Client: Let's do that. Can you confirm which barber I'm seeing when I return?

09 • Barber: You'll see Jordan at four. Please allow the full booked period for your visit.

10 • Client: Great. I'll come back for the appointment instead of waiting beside the empty chair.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

An offer is not a booking

A salon receptionist calls a client on the waiting list.

01 • Receptionist: A cancellation has opened tomorrow at eleven. Are you still interested in that time?

02 • Client: Possibly, but I need to check whether my colleague can cover my shift first.

03 • Receptionist: I can hold this offered slot until four today while you check with them.

04 • Client: Does that mean it is already booked, even if I don't call you back?

05 • Receptionist: No. It is temporarily held; we need your confirmation before four to book it.

06 • Client: Understood. My colleague will be back at three, so I can answer after that.

07 • Receptionist: Would a call to this number be the easiest way to confirm your decision?

08 • Client: Yes. If I can't take it, I'd still like to stay on the waiting list.

09 • Receptionist: That's fine. Today's hold expires at four, but your waiting-list request can remain.

10 • Client: I'll call with a definite answer after three rather than assuming the hold is permanent.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Booking time and handling appointment changes

A haircut appointment at 2:00 is running twenty minutes late. The usual service duration is forty minutes. The client must leave by 2:45. A 10:00 appointment tomorrow is available; the stylist cannot promise a shortened service today. This salon waives the change fee when its delay causes this rescheduling.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Client: must leave by 2:45 today; tomorrow at ten is possible if today's complete service will not fit.

Second round: The client offers to skip the consultation. Keep the complete appointment's timing and assessment needs clear.

Scenario 2 | Two people, one online appointment

Two friends arrive under one forty-minute haircut booking. Only one service is reserved. A second full slot is available at five; the friends cannot both stay until then.

Role A: Receptionist: explain what is booked and offer a separate slot.

Role B: Client: keep your appointment; your friend can come tomorrow at noon, which is also open.

Possible opening: We put both our names in the note, so are both haircuts included?

Success checks

- Distinguish a note from a second booking.
- Do not halve the service time as an automatic solution.
- Confirm separate appointments and names aloud.

Add a complication: The client asks to divide the forty minutes equally.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Pressure before the water starts

A stylist checks a client's comfort at the basin.

01 • Stylist: Before we start the water, how does the neck support feel in this position?

02 • Client: It presses at the back. I was hoping I could just ignore it briefly.

03 • Stylist: You don't need to ignore discomfort. I'll pause here while we discuss the arrangement.

04 • Client: Could I sit up first? It's easier to show you where the pressure is.

05 • Stylist: Of course. Tell me whether you want to leave the basin while we talk.

06 • Client: Yes, please. I'm sorry if that means the appointment takes longer than expected.

07 • Stylist: Thank you for telling me. We need your comfort feedback, not an apology.

08 • Client: Can the other chair be considered, or is this the only arrangement available today?

09 • Stylist: I'll ask my colleague to review the available setup with you before washing starts.

10 • Client: That's what I need. Let's keep the wash paused until we've discussed it.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A cape that catches on a collar

A barber responds to a client's comfort request.

01 • Barber: Is there anything about the cape or chair you want me to check first?

02 • Client: The cape feels tight over my collar. Could we pause for a moment?

03 • Barber: Certainly. Is the pressure around the whole neck or mainly against the front?

04 • Client: Mainly the front, where the shirt button sits underneath the edge of the cape.

05 • Barber: Thank you. I'll stop preparing the cut so we can address that together.

06 • Client: I didn't want to interrupt after you'd started, so I'm mentioning it now.

07 • Barber: That's helpful. Please say something again if the arrangement still doesn't feel comfortable.

08 • Client: It already feels easier now that we've stopped. May I straighten my collar first?

09 • Barber: Yes, take your time. Then tell me how the cape feels before we continue.

10 • Client: My collar is settled now. Please check with me once the cape is back.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A fragrance preference is not a diagnosis

A client asks about a strongly scented styling product.

- 01 • Stylist:** Before discussing the finish, is there a product preference you want me to know?
- 02 • Client:** Strong fragrances bother me. I don't know whether that counts as an allergy.
- 03 • Stylist:** I'll note that sensitivity to fragrance. Which product's scent is bothering you today?
- 04 • Client:** The spray used nearby has a strong scent. I'd prefer not to use that.
- 05 • Stylist:** We can leave that product out while we discuss your preferences and the available alternatives.
- 06 • Client:** Could you tell me exactly which product you propose, instead of simply saying gentle?
- 07 • Stylist:** Yes. We can check its label together; I won't promise it cannot cause a reaction.
- 08 • Client:** I'd rather skip a finishing product today if we can't resolve my concern.
- 09 • Stylist:** Understood. No finishing spray today, and your concern remains described in your own words.
- 10 • Client:** Thank you. That choice is clear without putting a medical label on my preference.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Checking comfort and pausing clearly

Before a wash, a client says the neck support feels uncomfortable. Water has not started. Ask the client to describe the pressure, pause preparation, and arrange a comfort check. Do not diagnose the discomfort or prescribe a position.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Client: feel pressure at the back of the neck before washing; want to sit up and discuss comfort.

Second round: The client apologizes for slowing the appointment. Acknowledge the concern without minimizing the discomfort.

Scenario 2 | A quieter consultation

A client says the music makes the consultation hard to hear. A quieter chair is available, and reception can lower the music in the consultation area.

Role A: Stylist: offer the quieter chair and repeat the length request.

Role B: Client: prefer to move and want to see the stylist's face during discussion.

Possible opening: Could we go somewhere quieter before deciding on the length?

Success checks

- Do not treat the earlier nod as agreement.
- Offer the stated quieter option.
- Repeat and confirm the actual haircut preference.

Add a complication: The client nodded earlier but now says they missed the question.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

The finish is a separate choice

A stylist explains a fictional menu before starting: haircut forty-five dollars, optional finish fifteen, and no additional charges.

01 • Stylist: The service menu lists your haircut at forty-five. Did you want the fifteen-dollar finishing add-on?

02 • Client: I thought the forty-five-dollar price covered both. What would the complete amount be?

03 • Stylist: Both services would be sixty dollars altogether, with no other charges added to that amount.

04 • Client: I can spend sixty, but I'd like to know what choice I actually have.

05 • Stylist: You can select the haircut alone for forty-five or add the finish for fifteen.

06 • Client: Then I'll take the haircut alone. I don't need the extra finish this afternoon.

07 • Stylist: Certainly. I'll confirm the haircut-only booking and won't add the optional service later.

08 • Client: Could I have an itemized receipt showing just the service I chose today?

09 • Stylist: Yes, it will list the haircut at forty-five, with no separate finishing charge.

10 • Client: That's clear now. Thank you for explaining the difference before I made the decision.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A starting price needs a specific estimate

A client phones about a service menu.

01 • Receptionist: You asked about the color consultation. Which part of the menu price needs clarification?

02 • Client: It says starting at eighty. Does that mean every color appointment costs eighty dollars?

03 • Receptionist: No. That's the starting price, not a quote for every possible color service.

04 • Client: What would I need before deciding whether a particular appointment fits my budget?

05 • Receptionist: The stylist needs to assess the requested service and explain a specific estimate.

06 • Client: Could I attend the consultation without committing to buy the service immediately afterward?

07 • Receptionist: Yes. Today's offer is a consultation, and its stated fee is separate from treatment.

08 • Client: Please tell me that fee too, so I can compare what I'm actually booking.

09 • Receptionist: The consultation is twenty dollars here. Any later service estimate would be discussed separately.

10 • Client: Then book the consultation only. I'll decide about a service after hearing its estimate.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A product quantity is not a discount

A client compares two sizes of styling cream.

01 • Stylist: These are the two sizes you asked about: fifty milliliters and one hundred milliliters.

02 • Client: The larger one costs more overall. Is it still cheaper for the same amount?

03 • Stylist: The small one is twelve dollars; the large one is twenty dollars for twice the quantity.

04 • Client: So two small containers would cost twenty-four, compared with twenty for the large one?

05 • Stylist: That's right for these displayed prices. Which size fits your likely use and budget?

06 • Client: The small one. I haven't tried it, and I don't want a bigger purchase today.

07 • Stylist: Certainly. Choosing the smaller size is fine even though its price per milliliter is higher.

08 • Client: Will buying it affect the haircut price or add anything else to my booking?

09 • Stylist: No. It's a separate twelve-dollar product purchase; your agreed haircut charge doesn't change.

10 • Client: Then I'll take one small container. Please list it separately on the receipt.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Explaining services, prices, and product choices

The fictional menu lists a haircut at \$45 and an optional finish at \$15, with no other charges in this exercise. A client thinks \$45 includes the finish. Neither service has begun. Explain the \$60 combined total and the \$45 haircut-only choice.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Client: assumed the finish was included; can spend sixty but want a genuine choice.

Second round: The client asks whether buying a product makes the finish free. No such offer exists in the supplied menu.

Scenario 2 | A beard service was not included

The haircut price is \$30; a beard trim is separately listed at \$12. The client requested both verbally but no total was agreed. Neither has started.

Role A: Barber: explain the \$42 combined price and the \$30 alternative.

Role B: Client: have a \$35 budget and prefer the haircut today.

Possible opening: I thought the beard trim came with the haircut.

Success checks

- Use the supplied prices only.
- Confirm the haircut-only choice.
- Do not imply the declined service will happen anyway.

Add a complication: The client asks whether a shorter beard trim has an unpublished lower price.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

The left side looks longer

A client raises a concern before checkout.

01 • Stylist: You look uncertain about the result. Which area would you like to discuss together?

02 • Client: The left seems longer than the right. I expected the outline to look even.

03 • Stylist: Let's review the asymmetry you're noticing on the left before we continue with checkout.

04 • Client: Thank you. I wasn't sure whether mentioning it would sound as though I was complaining.

05 • Stylist: It's useful to be specific. Can you point to the section you mean?

06 • Client: This part near my jaw. In the front mirror it appears lower than the other side.

07 • Stylist: I see the area you're indicating. We should review the shape before discussing any adjustment.

08 • Client: Would that review automatically mean cutting more off both sides to make them match?

09 • Stylist: No. We haven't agreed on a change; we'll discuss any proposal with you first.

10 • Client: Please keep that distinction clear. I want to understand the options before losing more length.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A blunt message needs a correction

A receptionist repairs an earlier response to a service query.

01 • Receptionist: I said there was nothing we could do. That was too broad, and I'm sorry.

02 • Client: I took that to mean nobody would even listen to my concern about the finish.

03 • Receptionist: A service review is available. I should have distinguished that from a guaranteed refund.

04 • Client: I'm not asking you to decide the refund now. I want someone to hear me.

05 • Receptionist: The stylist can review your concern at four today. Would that time work?

06 • Client: Yes. Should I bring the photograph we discussed before the original appointment as well?

07 • Receptionist: Please do. It will help explain which part of the agreed look concerns you.

08 • Client: Will the review cost anything, or does booking it commit me to another service?

09 • Receptionist: The review is free. Any goodwill gesture needs the manager's agreement; no further service is booked.

10 • Client: Then four works. Thank you for correcting the impression rather than repeating the earlier refusal.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A concern after a different home finish

A client returns with a question about the haircut's appearance.

01 • Stylist: Tell me what looks different today compared with the finish you saw in the salon.

02 • Client: The front sits flatter after I washed it. I thought the volume was from the haircut.

03 • Stylist: So the difference concerns how the front sits, not its actual length today?

04 • Client: Yes. I don't think more length has disappeared; it simply doesn't look as full.

05 • Stylist: Thank you. The salon finish and the underlying cut are different things to discuss.

06 • Client: I wish that distinction had been clearer. I assumed it would look identical every morning.

07 • Stylist: I'm sorry we didn't explain that expectation clearly. Let's review the look you wanted.

08 • Client: Could we discuss options without automatically booking a new cut or buying a product?

09 • Stylist: Absolutely. This conversation is a review of your concern, not an agreement to another purchase.

10 • Client: That helps. I'd like to understand the difference before deciding whether to change anything.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Responding to a concern about the result

A client says the left side looks longer. The earlier explanation promised an even outline, but the current appearance has not been reviewed together. Pause checkout, acknowledge the concern, and offer mirror review with the stylist. No correction or refund has been approved.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Client: the left appears longer; want to show the difference without being dismissed.

Second round: The client asks whether acknowledging the concern means the salon has approved a free adjustment.

Scenario 2 | The requested parting was misunderstood

A client requested a left-side parting but sees a center parting in the finish. No additional cutting has happened. The stylist can review the request now.

Role A: Stylist: acknowledge the specific misunderstanding and invite review.

Role B: Client: want the left-side appearance, not a shorter cut.

Possible opening: I meant a parting on the left, not through the center.

Success checks

- Name the parting concern accurately.
- Do not turn it into a request to cut more hair.
- Confirm what the client wants reviewed.

Add a complication: A colleague assumes the complaint is about haircut length.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

A color inquiry reaches reception

A stylist hands a client visit over to reception.

01 • Stylist: Today's client kept the front length and chose no finishing spray. Please preserve both preferences.

02 • Receptionist: I've noted those. Is the color consultation already booked, or was it only discussed today?

03 • Stylist: Only discussed. The client asked about future dates, but hasn't selected one yet.

04 • Receptionist: Then I should offer consultation times, not describe the next visit as confirmed color treatment.

05 • Stylist: Exactly. Please check the client's choice directly rather than carrying a date over from another visit.

06 • Receptionist: Is there any permission for a promotional photograph with the new haircut this afternoon?

07 • Stylist: No permission has been given. Don't interpret the service note as agreement to photography.

08 • Receptionist: Understood. I'll ask only about booking times now and keep any photo request separate.

09 • Stylist: Please tell me which consultation date is accepted, or leave it clearly unbooked.

10 • Receptionist: I will. The next task is offering dates; neither color service nor photography is agreed.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Keeping an internal photograph private

A stylist clarifies a client's limited photo permission.

01 • Stylist: Would you like a reference photo in your client record for the next consultation?

02 • Client: Yes, that would help me remember the outline, but I don't want it posted publicly.

03 • Stylist: So you're agreeing to the stated record use only, not social media or promotional material.

04 • Client: That's right. I saw the salon's photo display and wanted to make the difference clear.

05 • Stylist: Thank you. We'll handle the image under our record arrangements and note that limited permission.

06 • Client: Can I choose not to have any photo taken after all if I feel uncomfortable?

07 • Stylist: Yes. We can use a descriptive service note instead; a photograph isn't required for rebooking.

08 • Client: Actually, I'd prefer the note today. Please describe the retained length and the front shape.

09 • Stylist: No photograph today, then. I'll preserve those preferences in the note for the next stylist.

10 • Client: That suits me. I'm glad agreeing to an appointment doesn't require agreeing to a picture.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A new barber checks an old note

A covering barber discusses a returning client's recorded preference.

01 • Barber: Your previous note says short sides. Is that still what you want for today's visit?

02 • Client: Not this time. I'm growing the sides out and only want to discuss the neckline.

03 • Barber: Thank you. The old service note describes that visit, not a permanent instruction for every haircut.

04 • Client: Could you keep the older note but make today's changed preference clear for next time?

05 • Barber: Yes. Today's discussion will state that you're growing the sides and reviewing the neckline only.

06 • Client: There's also an old note about beard trimming. I don't want that service today either.

07 • Barber: I'll keep that separate. No beard trim is requested as part of this appointment.

08 • Client: Can we check the visible outline before anything starts, even though I'm a returning client?

09 • Barber: Certainly. Returning doesn't remove the need to confirm what you want on this particular visit.

10 • Client: Then let's look at the neckline together and keep both the sides and beard unchanged.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Passing preferences to the next appointment

A client requests a future color consultation but has not booked it. Reception is taking over. Today's confirmed preferences are retained front length and no finishing spray. The client has not agreed to promotional photographs. Handover the preferences and unbooked request accurately.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Receptionist: need to offer consultation dates and keep today's preferences separate from a future service.

Second round: The client consents to an internal reference photo but not publication. Repeat the limited permission.

Scenario 2 | A consultation time offered by voicemail

Reception offered Tuesday at noon but received no reply. The client arrives asking about a Friday slot instead; Friday at three is available.

Role A: Receptionist: distinguish the unaccepted Tuesday offer from a booking.

Role B: Client: prefer Friday at three and want confirmation by text.

Possible opening: Was Tuesday already booked just because you left that message?

Success checks

- Explain that suggested does not mean accepted.
- Confirm Friday at three directly.
- Keep the record clear about which offer was accepted.

Add a complication: A colleague's note says 'Tuesday suggested' without showing a response.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and switches roles and repeats the exchange. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All clients, prices, timings, products, and incidents are fictional English practice. This course is not training in cutting, shaving, chemical services, infection control, or diagnosis. Technical suitability and any health concern require the appropriately qualified professional and applicable local procedures. Sample salon policies are not universal rules.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

BLS Occupational Outlook Handbook: Barbers, Hairstylists, and Cosmetologists

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/personal-care-and-service/barbers-hairstylists-and-cosmetologists.htm>

O*NET OnLine: Hairdressers, Hairstylists, and Cosmetologists

<https://www.onetonline.org/link/summary/39-5012.00>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the following prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Vocabulary and grammar prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has four practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

Each starter prompt uses B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-30. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Rehearse with an AI colleague

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT | ONLINE VERSION

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Hairdressing and Barbering English

Professional audience: Hairstylists, barbers, salon assistants, and salon reception staff

Scope: All clients, prices, timings, products, and incidents are fictional English practice. This course is not training in cutting, shaving, chemical services, infection control, or diagnosis. Technical suitability and any health concern require the appropriately qualified professional and applicable local procedures. Sample salon policies are not universal rules.

Dialogue 01: The parent and the wearer want different lengths

Original fictional setting: A stylist checks a teenage client's preferences; booking permission is already settled.

Professional roles: Stylist / Client

Published dialogue (reference script, not my own performance):

Stylist: Your parent showed me a short photograph. Which parts of it appeal to you personally?

Client: I want neater hair, but I don't want my ears completely exposed like that.

Stylist: Which areas bother you now, and which lengths would you prefer to keep today?

Client: The front falls into my eyes. I like tucking the sides behind my ears.

Stylist: Then let's discuss the front separately. We don't have to copy the whole photograph.

Client: Can we explain that? My parent thinks booking a haircut means agreeing to their photograph.

Stylist: We'll summarize your preference together. First, do you want any change at the back?

Client: Only a neater outline. I don't want the much shorter back shown in the picture.

Stylist: So, a clearer front, retained side length, and a discussion of the back before cutting.

Client: Yes. Please show me the proposed front length because short means different things to us.

Stylist: I'll indicate the point in the mirror. Nothing in this photograph overrides what we've agreed.

Client: That gives me something specific to explain. We're changing the front, not copying everything.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Interactive workplace role-play

1. Use the supplied case or dialogue as the starting situation. Give a two-sentence briefing and offer two relevant professional roles for me to choose from. For a supplied dialogue, use its actual roles. Ask which role I want, then stop and wait. Do not write my replies.
 2. After I choose, identify who you will play and the immediate communication goal. Play the other professional; where a meeting requires a third person, label each of your speakers clearly. Start with one natural workplace turn and wait for my reply. Keep most turns to one to three sentences and ask no more than one question at a time.
 3. Let the exchange develop across six to ten learner turns, or end earlier if I type "feedback". Respond to what I actually say. Include a plausible clarification, disagreement or tradeoff without silently changing the starting facts. Mark any added constraint as a fictional second-round variation. Do not resolve approvals, evidence or commitments that remain uncertain.
 4. Stay in role during the exchange. If my meaning is unclear, ask for clarification naturally. Give a hint only if I ask or cannot proceed. Do not deliver a model conversation in advance.
 5. At the debrief, quote two of my phrases: one successful choice and one worth improving. Check factual accuracy, language, register and whether the next step was clear. Give up to three focused suggestions. Ask me to retry the weakest turn; wait. Only then offer an alternative wording and a harder replay.
- Use voice replies when available. If I prefer selections, offer four plausible spoken replies and explain my choice before continuing. Do not require written compositions.

END PROMPT

Create more scenario dialogues

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT | ONLINE VERSION

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Client: That gives me something specific to explain. We're changing the front, not copying everything.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Extend the conversation library

1. Propose six distinct, common scenarios in this field beyond the supplied case or script. For each, name the setting, two or more professional roles, the communication problem and one useful terminology focus. Include routine coordination, clarification, a complication, disagreement, handoff and follow-up where relevant. Choose scenarios that fit this profession, rather than forcing unsuitable situations into it.
2. Ask me to choose one scenario, or request all six in sequence. Stop and wait. Do not write all the scripts before I choose.
3. For the selected scenario, write an original fictional dialogue of 12-18 substantial speaking turns between two or three professionals. Name each role, establish an actual work problem, and let the exchange progress through questions, clarification, competing constraints and a credible next step or explicitly unresolved issue. Use the occupation's natural nomenclature and register. Avoid an interview between a teacher and a learner, generic small talk, and inserting a glossary definition into every reply. Explain specialist terms outside the dialogue instead.
4. After the script, explain five useful expressions in context, identify two grammar or register choices and ask three questions about the speakers' reasoning. Withhold the answers until I attempt them. Add one role-switch challenge.
5. Before presenting a script, check names, numbers, chronology, roles and terminology for consistency. Label invented facts and acknowledge uncertain specialist usage. If I requested all six, deliver one complete script at a time and wait for "next". Make each scenario materially different.

END PROMPT